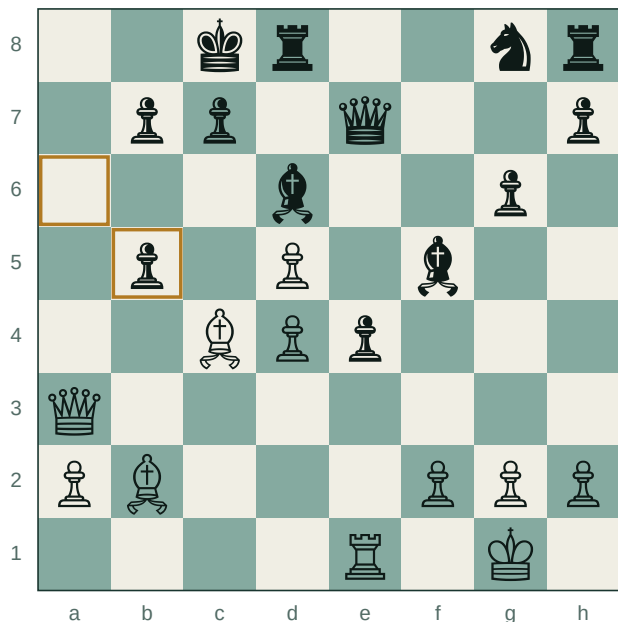


Intermediate moves: White, move 18

Intermediate moves

White to move



Previous move: 17...axb5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18. Qa8+ Kd7 19. Bxb5+ c6 20. Bxc6+ bxc6 21. Qxc6#

18.Qa8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **18...Kd7**.

19.Bxb5+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the pawn on b5. Recorded reply: **19...c6**.

20.Bxc6+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the pawn on c6. Recorded reply: **20...bxc6**.

21.Qxc6# Mate: queen on c6 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on d7. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Queen on c6. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

The postponed recapture may disappear. The intermediate move must win enough or preserve the right to recover material.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An intermediate move interrupts an expected sequence with a stronger immediate threat. Instead of recapturing automatically, use a check or another forcing move to change the result.

HOW TO LOOK

Before every routine recapture, scan checks, queen attacks, and mating threats. Return to the original capture only if it still helps.

The defending king is on c8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8. Check for tactical protection.